

dependence on the US for security. This will take the form of seeking to build their own strength, working with other partners and, willy-nilly, coming to an accommodation with China and Russia. Europe, particularly Germany, may well see China as the solution to basic questions about its economic future.

The issue, therefore, is what use China will make of the geopolitical space that the Trump administration's actions have opened up for it. China has no history of being a security provider or a provider of global public goods, even in the imperial tributary system. Her immediate reaction, therefore, is likely to be opportunistic but not to open her markets to the world or to undertake a role as international gendarme, as the US did.

For us in India, the direct impact of the trade and tariff wars is likely to be greater for our markets than for the economy since they are more integrated with the world. It may even be less for the Indian economy as a whole than for other similar economies. But the longer term indirect impacts should not be underestimated. Our economy, too, will find the going harder as global economic prospects darken. The US takes almost 20 per cent of our exports, and diverting them to other markets when everyone else is trying to do the same will not be easy.

Geopolitically, this will be a world where it is each one for themselves, a much more difficult world where power and force set the rules, as we see in West Asia and Europe. The only real answer is self-strengthening, which needs time and internal changes, and working with partners who share our interests, wherever we can find them. Concentrating on building a peaceful periphery must be a priority, as is working with friends in Asia.

In sum, President Trump has challenged us with the opportunity to re-evaluate our roles and integrate the subcontinent and the Indian Ocean region and in organisations like the Quad; to rejig our external economic policy to promote engagement, shifting from tariffs to a steady policy incentivising our industrialisation; to adjust policy towards China and continental Asia; and, most important, to undertake the self-strengthening and defence reforms that we know are necessary. This would utilise the phase transformation in geopolitics to further our national interest, doing the things we find hard in more stable and placid times. The list of tasks is long, and there is little time. ■

TIME TO PIVOT

- **Improve neighbourly ties:** Aim for integration of the subcontinent, the Indian Ocean Region and alliances like the Quad
- **Adjust policy towards China:** Trump's actions have opened up the geopolitical space for China
- **Undertake defence reforms:** These have been long overdue and have become imperative

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